

A STEP-BY-STEP PREPARATION HANDBOOK

IELTS BAND 7+

Listening · Reading · Writing · Speaking — decoded, drilled, and mastered

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1. Welcome: Your Path to Band 7+

If you have picked up this handbook, you already know what an IELTS band of 7 costs. It is the score universities ask for, the score that unlocks immigration points, the score that turns a strong CV into a competitive one. This handbook will not teach you English from the ground up — it assumes you can already read comfortably, hold a conversation, and write a coherent paragraph. What it gives you instead is something most candidates never get: the examiner’s lens. A clear, methodical understanding of what each band actually rewards, paired with techniques built specifically to move you off a 6 or 6.5 plateau and into the 7+ range.

1.1 What Band 7 Actually Means

On the official scale, Band 7 is described as a “Good User” of English — broadly equivalent to CEFR level C1. This is not the same as a flawless user. A Band 7 candidate still makes mistakes, still occasionally reaches for the wrong word, still hesitates. What separates them from a Band 6 candidate is range and control: they can handle unfamiliar topics, complex arguments, and abstract ideas without falling back on simple, repetitive language, and when they do make an error, it rarely interferes with meaning.

THE CORE IDEA

Band 7+ is not about eliminating mistakes. It is about flexibility under pressure — the ability to communicate complex ideas naturally, even imperfectly. Every section of this handbook is built around that single shift.

1.2 How Your Overall Band Is Calculated

Your overall band score is the average of your four component scores — Listening, Reading, Writing, and Speaking — rounded to the nearest half band. If the average ends in .25, it rounds up to the next half band; if it ends in .75, it rounds up to the next whole band. The score never rounds down. This means your weakest skill carries real leverage: lifting one component by half a band can move your entire overall result.

Listening	Reading	Writing	Speaking	Average	Overall Band
7.5	8.0	6.5	7.0	7.25	7.5
7.5	7.0	6.0	6.5	6.75	7.0

Both examples round up, never down — exactly as the official rule requires.

1.3 How to Use This Handbook

Work through Sections 2 and 3 first — they give you the map: the format, and the marking logic behind it. Sections 4 through 7 then hand you skill-specific techniques and short practice tasks designed to be done under real timing. Section 8 combines everything into one short timed mock so you can feel the cross-skill pressure in miniature. Section 9 turns the whole handbook into an eight-week plan, and Sections 10 and 11 are your final filters — the mistakes to eliminate and the checklist to run before you walk into the test centre.

PRACTICE HONESTLY

A practice task done without a timer measures your English. A practice task done against a clock measures your exam readiness — and it is the second one that predicts your band score.

2. Understanding the IELTS Exam

Before any strategy, a clear map. This section lays out the structure you are actually preparing for: which version of the test you need, how long each section takes, and what each band score broadly represents.

2.1 Academic vs General Training

IELTS comes in two versions, and choosing the right one matters before you choose any strategy. Academic IELTS is required for university admission and professional registration; its Reading passages are drawn from academic sources, and Task 1 of the Writing test asks you to describe a chart, graph, table, process, or map. General Training IELTS is used for migration, secondary education, and work; its Reading section draws on everyday and workplace texts, and Task 1 asks you to write a letter. Listening and Speaking are identical across both versions — the difference lives entirely in Reading and Writing.

2.2 Test Format at a Glance

Section	Duration	Tasks / Questions	Key Notes
Listening	~30 min audio, plus transfer time	4 sections, 40 questions	Played only once; difficulty increases through the test.
Reading	60 minutes	3 passages or sections, 40 questions	No separate transfer time — manage it within the 60 minutes.
Writing	60 minutes	Task 1 (≥150 words) + Task 2 (≥250 words)	Task 2 carries roughly twice the weight of Task 1 in your Writing band.
Speaking	11–14 minutes	3 parts	Recorded; face-to-face or by video call with a certified examiner.

2.3 The Nine Bands

Each skill is scored on a scale from 0 to 9, in half-band increments. The table below gives a general sense of what each range represents, based on Cambridge Assessment's published alignment between IELTS and the CEFR — treat it as a compass, not an exact conversion.

IELTS Band	Approx. CEFR	Broadly Means
8.5 – 9	C2	Expert command; fully operational, precise, and natural in virtually any context.

IELTS Band	Approx. CEFR	Broadly Means
7 – 8	C1 (Band 8 borders C1/C2)	Good to very good user; effective, flexible command with only occasional inaccuracies.
5.5 – 6.5	B2	Competent user; generally effective despite noticeable inaccuracies and some loss of flexibility.
4 – 5	B1	Limited user; partial command, frequent problems in unfamiliar situations.
Below 4	A2 and below	Basic to extremely limited user.

3. Band 7 Decoded: What Examiners Actually Reward

This is the most overlooked part of most candidates' preparation — and the one most likely to move your score. Understanding exactly what is being measured changes how you practise every day that follows.

3.1 The Four Criteria Behind Every Speaking and Writing Score

Both Writing and Speaking are marked against four criteria, each worth 25% of that skill's band score:

- **Fluency & Coherence (Speaking) / Coherence & Cohesion (Writing):** how smoothly your ideas connect, and how clearly the listener or reader can follow your logic.
- **Lexical Resource:** the range, precision, and naturalness of your vocabulary.
- **Grammatical Range & Accuracy:** how many different structures you control, and how accurately you use them.
- **Pronunciation (Speaking) / Task Achievement or Task Response (Writing):** for Speaking, how clear and natural you sound; for Writing, how fully and relevantly you address the actual question.

Listening and Reading, by contrast, are marked far more mechanically: each correct answer earns one point, and your raw score out of 40 converts to a band via a published conversion table. There is no partial credit and no extra penalty beyond a wrong or blank answer — which is precisely why guessing is always better than leaving a gap.

3.2 Band 6 vs Band 7 vs Band 8

A simplified comparison across the qualities examiners are listening and reading for, in both Speaking and Writing:

Aspect	Band 6	Band 7	Band 8
Vocabulary	Adequate but repetitive; relies on common, “safe” words.	Flexible vocabulary used with some precision and awareness of style.	Wide vocabulary used naturally, with skilful, idiomatic phrasing.
Grammar	A mix of simple and complex sentences; complex ones often contain errors.	A good range of complex structures; errors are occasional and rarely confusing.	A wide range of structures used with flexibility and very few errors.
Ideas / argument	Relevant but sometimes underdeveloped or repetitive.	Well-developed, relevant ideas with a clear position and logical progression.	Fully developed, nuanced ideas explored with precision.
Coherence	Generally organised, but linking can feel mechanical or overused.	Logically organised with clear progression; linking is varied and natural.	Organisation is seamless; cohesion is used so naturally it is barely noticeable.

3.3 The Band 7 Mindset

Most candidates stuck at 6 or 6.5 are not lacking knowledge — they are lacking range under pressure. They know complex grammar but default to simple sentences when nervous. They know precise vocabulary but reach for the first safe word that comes to mind. Band 7 is earned by candidates who have practised producing complex, varied, natural-sounding English until it becomes the default — not the effort.

4. Listening: Strategy and Technique

4.1 The Four Sections, Decoded

The Listening test always follows the same structure, getting harder as it goes. Knowing what to expect in each section lets you calibrate your concentration before it begins.

Section	Format	Context	What It Tests
1	Conversation, 2 speakers	Everyday/social (e.g. booking, enquiry)	Often form completion; the easiest section.
2	Monologue, 1 speaker	Everyday/social (e.g. a guide or announcement)	Following a single voice through factual detail.
3	Conversation, up to 4 speakers	Educational/training (e.g. students with a tutor)	Tracking who says what — usually the hardest to follow.
4	Monologue, 1 speaker	Academic (e.g. a lecture)	Sustained concentration; no break between questions.

4.2 Six Techniques That Separate a 6 from a 7

- **Predict before you hear:** use the time before each section starts to read the questions, underline keywords, and guess the type of answer needed — a number, a name, a place.
- **Listen for paraphrase, not exact words:** the audio will rarely use the same words as the question. Train yourself to recognise synonyms and reworded ideas in real time.
- **Expect distractors:** speakers often correct themselves mid-sentence (“It’s on Tuesday — actually, no, we moved it to Thursday”). The first answer mentioned is often a trap; the final, corrected one is usually the one that counts.
- **Respect the word limit exactly:** “NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS” means precisely that. Writing three words, or the right word with a spelling mistake, costs you the point even when your understanding was correct.
- **Build a personal shorthand:** practise abbreviating common words (“info,” “approx,” “&”) so you can keep writing while still listening to what comes next.
- **Never leave a blank:** an unanswered question is a guaranteed zero. An educated guess based on the expected answer type at least gives you a chance.

4.3 Mini Practice: Note-Taking Under Pressure

A handbook cannot give you real exam audio, but you can simulate the skill that determines most of the gap between Band 6 and Band 7: catching key information while a speaker keeps moving. Ask someone

to read the script below aloud at a natural pace — not slowly — while you complete the notes.
Alternatively, read it once yourself at normal speed, cover it, and reconstruct the answers from memory.

PRACTICE SCRIPT — LIBRARY MEMBERSHIP ENQUIRY

Librarian: Good morning, City Library, how can I help?

Caller: Hi, I'd like to apply for a membership, please.

Librarian: Of course. Can I take your full name?

Caller: It's Daniela Petrov — that's P-E-T-R-O-V.

Librarian: Thank you. And your date of birth?

Caller: The fourteenth of March, 1998.

Librarian: Great. We have two membership types: Standard, which is free, and Premium, which is twenty-two pounds a year but includes unlimited e-book downloads.

Caller: I'll go for the Premium one, please.

Librarian: No problem. We'll need proof of address — a utility bill or bank statement, dated within the last three months.

Caller: I can bring my bank statement.

Librarian: Perfect. Just one more thing — can I take a contact number, in case there's an issue with your application?

Caller: Yes, it's 07911 224 560.

1. Caller's surname: _____
2. Date of birth: _____
3. Membership type chosen: _____
4. Annual cost of Premium membership: £ _____
5. Document offered as proof of address: _____
6. Contact phone number: _____

ANSWER KEY

1. Petrov 2. 14 March 1998 3. Premium 4. £22 5. Bank statement 6. 07911 224 560

5. Reading: Strategy and Technique

5.1 Your 60 Minutes

Three passages, 60 minutes, no extra time to transfer answers — the arithmetic is unforgiving. A widely used rule of thumb is roughly 20 minutes per passage, including the time to transfer answers as you go (never leave transfer until the end). Many Band 7+ candidates adjust this slightly: skim all three passages for two or three minutes total, identify which one feels least demanding to them personally, and start there to bank early marks and momentum before tackling the more abstract passage last.

5.2 Skim, Scan, Read Closely — and Know Which Is Which

- **Skimming:** reading fast for gist — used to understand a passage’s overall topic and structure, or to match paragraphs to headings.
- **Scanning:** hunting for a specific detail — a date, a name, a number — without reading every word, used when you already know exactly what you’re looking for.
- **Close reading:** slow, careful reading of a short section, reserved for questions that depend on nuance, such as True/False/Not Given or the writer’s exact opinion.

Most candidates under Band 7 read every passage the same way: slowly, start to finish. That habit alone can cost 15–20 minutes you don’t have. Match your reading speed to the question type, not the passage.

5.3 Question Types and How to Beat Them

Question Type	Core Strategy
True / False / Not Given	Locate the matching section first, then judge: True = the statement matches the text; False = the text directly contradicts it; Not Given = the information simply isn’t there. Confusing False with Not Given is the single most common source of lost marks in the whole Reading test.
Yes / No / Not Given	Same logic as above, but applied to the writer’s opinions or claims rather than plain facts.
Matching Headings	Read each paragraph’s first and last sentence before its middle — topic sentences usually carry the main idea a heading needs to summarise.
Matching Information / Features	Treat it as a scanning task built around names, dates, or details — the question order rarely matches the order of the passage, so don’t assume it does.
Sentence / Summary Completion	Predict the missing word’s grammar — noun, verb, plural — before you search the passage. This narrows your search dramatically.
Multiple Choice	Eliminate options that are true of the passage but don’t answer the actual question — the most common wrong answer is a “true but irrelevant” distractor.

5.4 Mini Practice: Timed Passage

Set a timer for 7 minutes — roughly a third of the time you'd budget for a full passage, scaled to this shorter text — and answer the five questions below. Resist the urge to read the passage twice.

PASSAGE — URBAN BEEKEEPING AND THE UNEXPECTED RESILIENCE OF CITY BEES

Over the past two decades, beekeeping has migrated from rural farmland to rooftops, balconies, and community gardens in cities around the world. The trend began as a niche hobby but has since attracted the attention of urban planners and ecologists, who note that city-kept colonies often outperform their rural counterparts in both honey yield and winter survival rates. Several explanations have been proposed. Cities tend to be slightly warmer than the surrounding countryside — a phenomenon known as the urban heat island effect — which extends the foraging season for bees by several weeks. In addition, urban gardens and parks frequently host a wider variety of flowering plants across more of the year than monoculture farmland, where a single crop may bloom for only a few weeks before leaving bees with little to forage. Critics caution, however, that the rapid growth of urban beekeeping may be placing unsustainable pressure on a limited number of flowering plants in dense city centres, potentially disadvantaging wild pollinator species that cannot travel as far as honeybees to find food. Some local governments have begun capping the number of hives permitted per area in response to these concerns, attempting to balance the benefits of urban beekeeping against its ecological costs.

1. Urban beekeeping was originally a _____ before attracting wider professional interest.
(no more than two words)
2. True / False / Not Given: City-kept colonies generally produce less honey than rural colonies.
3. True / False / Not Given: Some local governments have introduced limits on the number of hives allowed in an area.
4. True / False / Not Given: Urban beekeeping has existed in cities for over a century.
5. What is identified as a possible negative consequence of growing urban beekeeping numbers? A) Falling honey prices in rural markets B) Reduced food availability for wild pollinators C) A decline in the urban heat island effect D) Local governments banning beekeeping entirely

ANSWER KEY

1. A niche hobby 2. False 3. True 4. Not Given 5. B

6. Writing: Strategy and Technique

6.1 Task 1 (Academic): Describing Visual Data

Task 1 rewards a specific four-paragraph shape far more reliably than creativity does:

- **1. Paraphrase the question** (one sentence) — restate what the chart shows without copying the prompt's wording.
- **2. Overview** (two to three sentences) — the single most important paragraph for Band 7+: state the two or three most significant overall trends or comparisons, with no specific numbers yet.
- **3 & 4. Supporting detail** — group similar data together (e.g. the two rising trends in one paragraph, the falling trend in another) and support each with specific figures.

THE MOST EXPENSIVE MISTAKE IN TASK 1

A striking number of candidates skip the overview paragraph entirely, assuming the data “speaks for itself” once every figure is listed. It doesn't. To an examiner, an overview is direct evidence that you can identify what matters in a dataset — precisely what Task Achievement assesses. Missing it is one of the fastest ways to be capped at Band 5 or 6, regardless of how accurate your sentences are.

Your Band 7+ checklist for Task 1:

- A clear overview identifying the two or three most significant features — kept general, not a fourth detail paragraph in disguise.
- No invented data and no personal opinion — Task 1 is purely descriptive.
- A genuine attempt at comparison and synthesis, not just a list of every number on the chart.
- At least 150 words, written within roughly 20 minutes.
- A varied range of structures for describing change and comparison — see Section 6.4.

A model overview, to show the shape rather than give away an answer (your real practice prompt is in Section 6.5): “Overall, X increased steadily over the period while Y declined, and Z remained comparatively stable throughout.” Notice what it does not contain — no specific numbers, just the two or three headline patterns a reader needs before the detail.

6.2 Task 1 (General Training): Letter Writing

General Training candidates write a letter instead of describing data, in one of three registers, matched to who the letter is addressed to:

- **Formal** — an unfamiliar person or organisation (e.g. a complaint to a company).
- **Semi-formal** — someone you don't know personally but have a working relationship with (e.g. a landlord).

- **Informal** — a friend or family member.

Every prompt gives you three bullet points to cover; address all three with genuine development, not one rushed sentence each. The most common register mistake is drifting into informal phrasing partway through a formal letter — consistency matters as much as correctness.

Function	Informal / Band 6 phrasing	Formal / Band 7+ phrasing
Opening	Just wanted to let you know...	I am writing to inform you that...
Requesting	Could you maybe...?	I would be grateful if you could...
Closing	Best / Take care	Yours faithfully (unknown name) / Yours sincerely (named recipient)

6.3 Task 2: The Essay

Task 2 questions fall into four recurring types: Opinion (agree/disagree), Discussion (discuss both views), Problem-Solution, and Advantage-Disadvantage — sometimes combined with a request for your opinion. Identifying the type correctly is the single highest-leverage decision you make in Task 2: answer a “discuss both views” question with only your own opinion, and your Task Response score is capped regardless of how good your English is.

A reliable four-paragraph structure:

- **Introduction:** paraphrase the question, then state a clear thesis or position.
- **Body 1:** one main idea, fully developed — state it, explain why or how, then give a specific example or consequence.
- **Body 2:** a second main idea, developed with the same depth.
- **Conclusion:** summarise your position; introduce no new ideas.

“Fully developed” is doing the real work in that structure. One underdeveloped idea per paragraph — a claim with no explanation or example behind it — is a far more common Band 6 ceiling than a shortage of vocabulary.

6.4 Cohesive Devices Worth Using at Band 7+

Function	Band 6 (overused)	Band 7+ alternative
Adding a point	Also / And	Furthermore / In addition / What is more
Contrasting	But	However / That said / Whereas / Although
Giving a result	So	As a result / Consequently / This, in turn,
Giving an example	For example (repeated)	This is illustrated by... / A clear case in point

Function	Band 6 (overused)	Band 7+ alternative
		is...
Summarising	In conclusion	On balance / Taking everything into account

A WORD OF CAUTION

Band 7+ is not about swapping every simple word for a complex one — that often backfires and reads as unnatural. The actual skill is variety and precision: a range of devices, used accurately and in the right place, rather than the same one repeated throughout.

6.5 Mini Practice: Task 1 and Task 2 Prompts

Do both prompts today, back-to-back, exactly as you would on test day: Task 1 first with a 20-minute timer, then Task 2 immediately after with a 40-minute timer, no break in between.

Task 1 (Academic): The graph below shows average weekly hours spent on three leisure activities by adults in a fictional country between 2000 and 2020. Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant. Write at least 150 words.

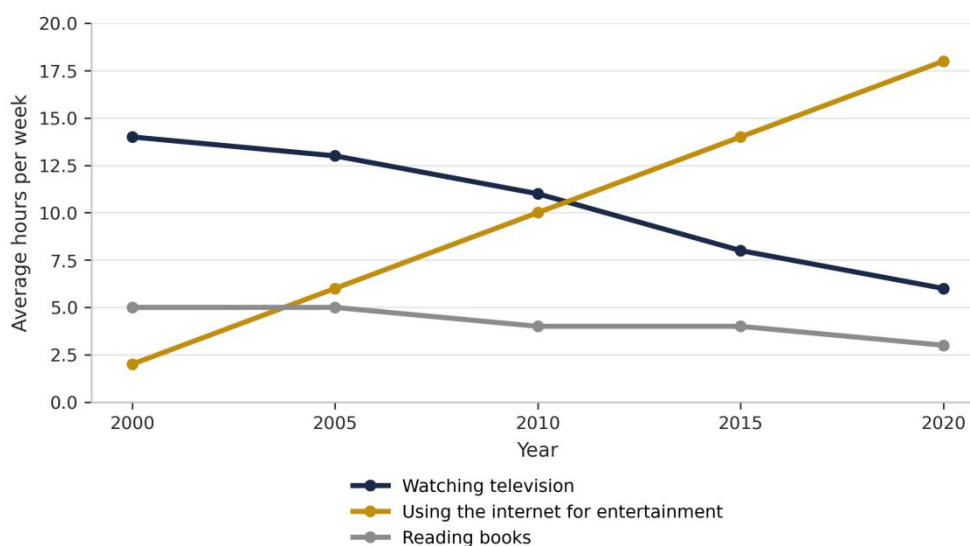


Figure 1. Average weekly hours spent on three leisure activities, 2000–2020 (fictional data, for practice purposes).

Task 2: Some people believe the most important benefit of a university education is that it increases students' employment opportunities. Others believe universities provide a wide range of important benefits that have nothing to do with employment. Discuss both these views and give your own opinion. Write at least 250 words.

Self-check both answers against the Band 7+ checklist in Section 6.1 and the structure in Section 6.3 before moving on.

7. Speaking: Strategy and Technique

7.1 The Three Parts

Part	Duration	Format	Topics
1	4–5 min	Q&A with the examiner	Familiar everyday topics — home, work or study, hobbies, routine.
2	3–4 min	Long turn from a cue card (1 min prep + up to 2 min talk + brief follow-up)	A described experience, person, place, or object.
3	4–5 min	Two-way discussion	An abstract, more analytical extension of the Part 2 topic.

7.2 The Four Scoring Criteria, in Plain English

- **Fluency & Coherence:** speak at a natural pace with minimal unnatural pausing, and organise your answer logically — not just a long, unconnected list of facts.
- **Lexical Resource:** paraphrase rather than repeat the question’s words back, and use topic-appropriate vocabulary and natural collocations.
- **Grammatical Range & Accuracy:** show a range of tenses and structures — not just the present simple — with real control over the more complex ones you attempt.
- **Pronunciation:** clear individual sounds, but more importantly natural sentence stress, intonation, and rhythm — examiners assess whether you sound natural in connected speech, not whether your accent is “native.”

PRO TIP

Pronunciation at Band 7+ is not about losing your accent. Examiners are trained to assess clarity and natural rhythm, not accent itself — a strong Omani, French, or Korean accent paired with clear stress and intonation can score just as highly as a “native-sounding” one.

7.3 A Framework for Part 2

One minute of preparation feels short, but it is enough if you have a repeatable structure instead of trying to plan full sentences in advance. Try P-S-D-F:

- **Point:** state the core fact in one sentence — what, who, or where it is.
- **Story:** give the background — when, how, the context.
- **Detail:** add two or three specific, concrete details — sounds, people, sensory detail. Concrete detail is what separates a Band 6 answer from a Band 7 one.

- **Feeling:** close with your opinion or feeling about it, and why.

This structure naturally fills close to two minutes without requiring you to plan exact sentences — you are planning ideas, not language, which leaves your full attention free for grammar and vocabulary while you actually speak.

7.4 Mini Practice: Cue Card and Follow-Up

CUE CARD

Describe a skill you taught yourself. You should say: what the skill is · how you learned it · how long it took you to learn it — and explain how this skill has been useful to you.

Give yourself exactly one minute to prepare using the P-S-D-F framework above, then speak for up to two minutes without stopping — record yourself if you can, and listen back specifically for repeated words and unnaturally long pauses, the two habits that cost Band 6 candidates the most marks.

Part 3 follow-up, for extension practice:

1. Do you think self-taught skills are valued as highly as formally taught ones?
2. How has technology changed the way people learn new skills?

For each question, aim for at least three or four sentences: a direct answer, a reason, an example, and — where natural — a brief acknowledgment of a counter-view. One-sentence answers are the most common reason capable speakers score a 6 instead of a 7 in Part 3.

8. Putting It Together: A Timed Mini Mock

8.1 Instructions

This is a compressed simulation, not a full test — real IELTS Reading and Listening sections are roughly four times this length. Its purpose is to let you feel, in miniature, what it is like to move between skills under time pressure with no break, which is part of what makes the real exam harder than any single practice exercise suggests. Work through the three steps below in order, without pausing between them.

8.2 The Set

Step 1 (6 minutes) — read the passage and answer the four questions.

PASSAGE — THE RISE OF REMOTE WORK

Before 2020, fewer than one in twenty employees in most developed economies worked from home on a regular basis. The rapid shift to remote work during the global pandemic was initially treated by many employers as a temporary measure, yet several years on, a significant proportion of companies have retained flexible or fully remote arrangements permanently. Proponents point to measurable gains: reduced office overheads, wider talent pools no longer limited by commuting distance, and, according to several workplace surveys, improved employee satisfaction. Sceptics counter that remote work weakens informal mentorship, particularly for newer employees who benefit from observing senior colleagues in person, and that collaborative, creative tasks can suffer without spontaneous in-person interaction. A growing number of organisations have settled on hybrid models, requiring staff to be present in the office for a fixed number of days each week, as an attempted compromise between the two positions.

1. True / False / Not Given: Before 2020, remote work was the standard arrangement for most employees.
2. True / False / Not Given: All companies that adopted remote work during the pandemic have since returned fully to the office.
3. One advantage of remote work mentioned is access to a wider _____. (no more than two words)
4. According to the passage, sceptics are particularly concerned about remote work's effect on: A) office overhead costs B) mentorship for newer employees C) employee satisfaction surveys D) commuting distances

Step 2 (5 minutes) — outline only, not a full essay. Task 2 prompt: "Some people believe employees should be free to choose where they work, while others think companies should require staff to work from a shared office. Discuss both views and give your own opinion." Write only your thesis sentence and one topic sentence for each body paragraph — three sentences total, no more.

Step 3 (90 seconds, spoken aloud) — “Describe a piece of technology you find useful in your daily life and explain why.” Speak your answer aloud, recording it if possible.

ANSWER KEY — STEP 1

1. False 2. False 3. Talent pool(s) 4. B

8.3 Self-Assessment

- Reading: did you answer using only scanning for the factual questions, or did you read the whole passage twice? Reading it twice under time pressure is the single most common reason capable candidates run out of time.
- Writing: does your thesis sentence directly state a position, and does each topic sentence promise one clear idea? If a topic sentence doesn't preview what the paragraph will argue, the paragraph itself probably won't either.
- Speaking: did you keep talking, even briefly, when you lost your train of thought, or did you stop completely? Silence costs you Fluency & Coherence marks far more heavily than a small grammar slip does.

9. Your 8-Week Study Plan

This plan assumes roughly 60–90 minutes of focused daily practice. If your timeline is shorter, compress two weeks into one rather than skipping sections entirely — every skill in this handbook depends on the one before it.

Week	Focus	Daily / Weekly Practice
1	Diagnostic & foundations	Take one full practice test across all four skills under timed conditions to establish your baseline; review the band descriptors in Section 3.2 for your two weakest skills.
2	Listening + vocabulary	One Listening section daily, plus targeted vocabulary building in two or three topic areas (education, environment, technology), built around collocations rather than isolated words.
3	Reading	One timed passage daily, focusing on True/False/Not Given and Matching Headings — the two highest-error question types for most candidates. Review every wrong answer to find the pattern behind your mistakes.
4	Writing — Task 1	One Task 1 daily, rotating through chart types (line, bar, pie, table, process/map) or letters, focused purely on overview-writing speed and accuracy.
5	Writing — Task 2	One full essay every other day; on lighter days, just a thesis and two topic sentences for speed. Rotate through all four question types so none feels unfamiliar on test day.
6	Speaking	Record yourself daily answering one Part 1 set, one Part 2 cue card, and two Part 3 questions. Listen back and log repeated words and filler phrases.
7	Integration	A full timed practice test every other day, alternating with focused review of your two weakest criteria from Section 3.2.
8	Consolidation & simulation	One full, strictly timed mock test in exam-day conditions, at the same time of day as your real exam, with no pauses. The remaining days are light review only — new material this close to the exam tends to create doubt, not improvement.

10. Fifteen Mistakes That Cap Candidates Below Band 7

None of these mistakes reflect a lack of English ability — they reflect exam habits that quietly cap a score that the candidate's actual language would otherwise support. Most candidates fix two or three of these and see a genuine jump within weeks.

LISTENING

1. Writing answers in the gaps after the recording has moved on, instead of in real time — losing the next answer while fixing the last one.
2. Ignoring the word limit instruction and writing extra words “just in case.”
3. Assuming the first-mentioned option is correct and missing a spoken correction or change of plan.
4. Leaving a blank instead of guessing when unsure.

READING

5. Reading every passage start to finish before answering any question, instead of working question by question with targeted scanning.
6. Confusing “False” with “Not Given” — treating “the text doesn't mention it” the same as “the text contradicts it.”
7. Spending more than two or three minutes stuck on a single hard question instead of moving on and returning later.
8. Not checking that transferred answers — spelling, capitalisation — match the passage exactly.

WRITING

9. Skipping or rushing the overview paragraph in Task 1.
10. Memorising a “template essay” and forcing the actual prompt to fit it, producing an answer that doesn't fully address the question — a direct cap on Task Response.
11. Writing under the minimum word count, or padding past it with repetition rather than genuine development.
12. Using complex vocabulary inaccurately purely to “sound advanced” — an inaccurate complex word scores lower than an accurate simple one.

SPEAKING

13. Giving one-word or one-sentence answers, especially in Parts 1 and 3, instead of extending naturally.
14. Reciting a memorised answer that doesn't actually match the cue card or question — examiners are trained to recognise this, and it caps Fluency & Coherence.

15. Going completely silent when stuck, instead of using natural filler or repair language (“That’s an interesting question, let me think...”) to buy time while staying in the conversation.

11. Exam Day Checklist and Final Reminders

The Night Before

- Confirm your test centre address and arrival time, and plan your route with extra buffer time.
- Do a light review only — skim your cohesive devices table and the band descriptors in Section 3.2, but avoid new material or a full mock test.
- Prepare your ID and printed confirmation the night before, not the morning of.
- Sleep is a more reliable performance booster at this stage than one more hour of study.

What to Bring

- Valid passport or ID — the exact document you registered with, which must match exactly.
- Your test confirmation or admission notice, if required by your test centre.
- Nothing else is typically needed — most centres provide all materials and prohibit bringing your own pens, phones, or watches into the room.

During the Exam

- In Listening and Reading, never leave a question blank — guess based on the expected answer type if you run out of time.
- In Writing, check your word count and re-read your overview or thesis in the final two minutes — these are the highest-leverage sentences in the whole task.
- In Speaking, treat the examiner like a person you're having a real conversation with, not a panel judging you — natural engagement consistently scores better than a stiff, over-rehearsed delivery.

A Final Word

Band 7+ is not a talent ceiling — it is a strategy and stamina ceiling. Almost every candidate who reaches it does so not because their English suddenly improves overnight, but because they stop wasting marks on avoidable, mechanical mistakes: a missed overview, a one-word Part 1 answer, a blank left on a Listening question they could have guessed. Work through this handbook methodically, practise honestly under time pressure, and trust the process. You already have more English than you think — this handbook's only job is to help you spend it efficiently.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

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Rayene Medabis designs curricula, training frameworks, and learning resources for educators and language learners, drawing on instructional design, applied linguistics, and the practical realities of the classroom. Her work bridges theory and practice for teachers, curriculum designers, and learners working to reach the next level in their craft.

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